DBQ Point Guide 1: Thesis/Claim

Oct 28, 2026 · @CJ DeRuyter

What the rubric requires

The thesis point (Row A, 1 pt) goes to a historically defensible claim that answers the prompt and establishes a line of reasoning. It is built from the College Board 2023–2025 scoring guidelines and the nine scored sample sets in DBQ Grading Criteria.

A thesis earns the point only if all four are true:

1. **It answers the actual question.** It takes a position on the prompt's topic and time period, not a neighboring topic.
2. **It is historically defensible.** A reader who knows the period could argue for it with real evidence.
3. **It establishes a line of reasoning.** It gives *either* a reason for the claim ("because…", "by…", "as…", "through…") *or* categories the essay will use (political, economic, social; or three named developments).
4. **It sits in one place.** One or more consecutive sentences, in the introduction *or* the conclusion. Pieces scattered across the essay don't combine.

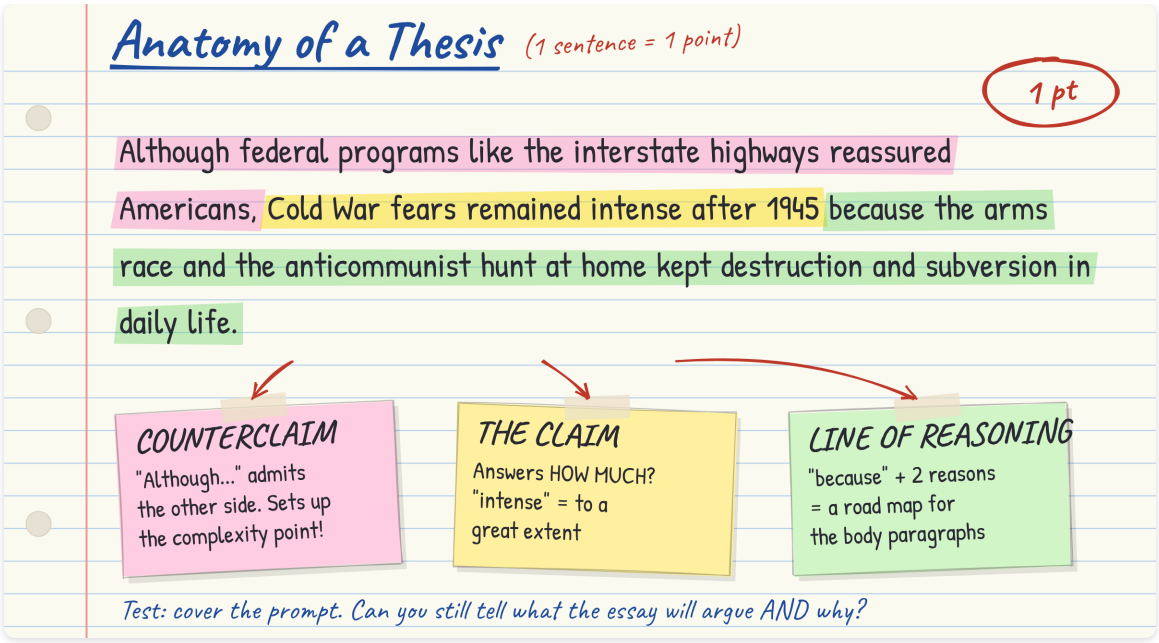
What readers actually credit is a low bar. College Board labels "Slavery caused division between the North and the South" as a minimally acceptable thesis. Every 2-point essay in the samples (2023–2025, set 1 and set 2) still earned Row A. The point is lost only when the sentence restates the prompt, drifts off topic, or makes a claim with no reason or categories attached.

Extent language ("to a great extent", "largely", "only partially") is not strictly required; several credited theses have none. Teach it anyway, because it forces students to evaluate, and it sets up the complexity point.

The foolproof formula

Teach students one sentence frame and the thesis point becomes automatic:

> **Although** [counterclaim or limit], [prompt topic] [changed / shaped / was effective] **to a [great / limited] extent** from [start year] to [end year] **because / through** [category 1], [category 2], and [category 3].



1. **Circle the task verb and the topic** in the prompt. "Evaluate the extent" means the thesis must say *how much*.
2. **Copy the time frame.** Using the prompt's dates keeps the claim on topic.
3. **Pick three categories** from the documents: group the 7 docs into 2–3 clusters (for example, foreign policy, domestic spending, public anxiety). Each cluster becomes a body paragraph.
4. **Attach a reason word**: because, by, through, as, which led to. This is what turns a claim into a line of reasoning.
5. **Add the "Although" clause.** It costs one phrase and sets up the complexity point (see Guide 6).
6. **Keep it in one place.** Last sentence(s) of the introduction. Repeat a version in the conclusion as insurance; the reader will credit either one.

Test before moving on: Cover the prompt. If the sentence still tells a reader what the essay will argue *and why*, it earns the point. If it only makes sense as an echo of the prompt, rewrite it.

Examples that earned the point

Student sample theses are quoted verbatim, errors included, from the College Board scoring commentaries.

Source	Thesis	Why it earned the point
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	"From 1783 to 1840, slavery deeply shaped American society both politically through creating moral debates and religiously through disagreements over its Biblical legitimacy."	Extent word ("deeply") plus two categories, political and religious, each with a reason.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	"Although the federal government became very involved in the United States Economy between… the early and middle part of the 1932 to 1980 due to a new line of Keynsian Economic thinking, the later part was characterized by a more Laissez-Faire level of government intervention as the New Right began to become popularized."	Shows change over time with a cause for each phase. The "Although" structure also set up complexity.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	"…beliefs about threats to the United States… [shaped] society from 1917 to 1945 by leading to increased isolationism, opposition to communism, and fear of and disregard for immigrants."	"By leading to" plus three categories that became three body paragraphs.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	"Although there continued to be a discrepancy of rights between different groups, more people joined the ranks of citizen from 1865 to 1920 and debates over citizenship changed the definition of it during this time period."	Takes a clear position (citizenship expanded) and qualifies it.
2025 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 2)	"…Productivity increased through the completion of the transcontential railroad… The fight for better workforce treatment started… And the stopping of monopolies happened through the creation of Trust Control Laws."	Located in the **conclusion**, which is allowed. Several sentences in one place count as one thesis.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1C (score 2)	"The role of the federal government… changed from 1932 to 1980 by creating and funding projects ansd innovations that would later on benefit everyone…"	College Board called this "minimally defensible" with a "generalized line of reasoning." It starts with the prompt but adds "by creating and funding projects."
2024 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	"During times of great threats to the nation, Americans are very fearful of their adversaries, and are constantly suspicious and on alert."	Thin, but it makes a defensible claim about how threats shaped society. Shows how low the floor is.

Model for the Cold War DBQ (written for this guide, not a student sample):

> "Although federal programs such as containment, the Interstate Highway Act, and the National Defense Education Act reassured Americans that the nation was prepared, Cold War fears remained intense after 1945 because the nuclear arms race and the anticommunist hunt at home kept the threat of destruction and subversion in daily life."

It has a counterclaim, an evaluation of effectiveness, and two reasons for continued fear. That answers both halves of the prompt.

Examples that did not earn the point

Failure type	Example	Why it fails
Paraphrases the prompt, reason is circular	2024 Set 2, Sample 1C: the documents "provide evidence that supports the claim that foreign threats affected the US society to a large extent because they all changed the way that society was run."	Has an extent phrase and a "because," but the reason only repeats the claim. Listing document numbers is not a line of reasoning.
Restates the prompt	"The institution of slavery shaped United States society." (2024 guidelines) / "The role of the federal government in the United States economy changed from 1932 to 1980." (2025)	Nothing added beyond the prompt's own words.
Defensible, no line of reasoning	"The United States industrialized in the 1800s." (2025) / "There were a lot more security threats to the United States after 1917." (2024)	True, but there's no reason or category telling the reader where the essay goes.
Off topic	"Slavery had a big impact on fighting the Civil War." (2024) / "The Civil Rights movement changed US society a lot between 1917 and 1945." (2024)	Answers a different question or a different time period.
Overgeneralized or not defensible	"The federal government was not very interested in the United States economy from 1932 to 1980." (2025)	A reader can't defend it with evidence from the period.
Vague sweep	"There were some social and political changes to definitions of citizenship during Reconstruction." (2023)	"Some changes" takes no real position.
Split thesis	A claim in the introduction and the categories in the conclusion	The rubric requires one place. Readers won't stitch them together.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- "After World War II Americans had Cold War fears and the government tried to address them." Restates the prompt.
- "The Cold War was a conflict between the United States and the Soviet Union." Defensible, but doesn't answer either half of the prompt.

Expert tips (Heimler's History)

Steve Heimler, a national AP reader, adds steps for reading the prompt before writing. These fit the rubric above.

Unpack the prompt first (How to Understand ANY DBQ Prompt, 2023; THREE Secrets to a Perfect DBQ, 2024):

1. **Translate the task.** "Evaluate the extent to which" means "determine *how much*." "Evaluate the relative importance" means "rank the causes."
2. **Mark the dates**, and write centuries as years (16th century → 1500s). An essay about the wrong period earns nothing.
3. **Mark the category.** If the prompt says *society*, political causes like the Missouri Compromise need a social angle to count.
4. **Name the skill**: causation, continuity and change, or comparison. If the prompt doesn't state one, choose one and stick to it.

His thesis formula (How to WRITE a THESIS):

> "Despite [counterargument], because [evidence 1] and [evidence 2], [argument]."

He calls this "packing the thesis like a haggis": name specific evidence (the Stamp Act and Sugar Act, not "taxes"). The counterargument isn't required for the point, but it sets up complexity.

From his "Does It Earn the Point?" review of College Board samples (video):

Thesis	Earns it?	Why
“Transatlantic voyages affected the Americas a whole bunch.”	No	Defensible, but no how or why.
“Transatlantic voyages affected the Americas by establishing regular commerce between the Americas and Europe.”	Yes (minimal)	"By…" adds the line of reasoning.
“The most significant factor affecting the development of the printing press was the demand for religious text during the Reformation.”	No	The prompt asked for *effects*; this argues *causes*. The skill doesn't match.
A specific claim about the Ming Dynasty's economic power	No	Specific, but it never addresses the prompt (change caused by European expansion).

Rubric note: naming specific evidence in the thesis is Heimler's recommendation for a stronger essay, not a rubric requirement. College Board's minimal theses only give a reason or categories, so grade against the checklist below.

Grader checklist

Answer in order. Any "no" means 0 points.

1. Is there a claim in the introduction or the conclusion, in consecutive sentences?
2. Does it address the prompt's topic within (or reaching into) the prompt's time frame?
3. Is it historically defensible?
4. Does it go beyond the prompt's own words?
5. Does it give a reason (because / by / through / as) **or** name categories of argument?

All five yes = 1 point. When in doubt on #5, ask: "Could I predict the body paragraphs from this sentence?" If yes, award it.

Feedback stems for students

- Earned: "Your thesis earns the point because it [names categories / gives a reason]: '[quote].'"
- Not earned: "Your thesis restates the prompt. Add *why* or *how* — for example, 'because…' followed by your 2–3 body-paragraph topics."